'stealth lobbying' by India to get Kashmir removed from his portfolio).[53] From that very moment, Indian diplomats began pressuring the US to stay the course in Afghanistan. This is reflected in a series of meetings between Indian, American, and British officials throughout 2009.

In February, EAM Pranab Mukherjee told Holbrooke that India favoured an integrated 'Af-Pak' approach, but wanted greater political commitment from the US.[54] Menon informed Holbrooke that India had a 'huge stake' in the latter's success in Afghanistan.[55] At the mid-level, MEA joint secretary T. C. A. Raghavan told his US counterpart that the US decision to bring the Taliban to the negotiating table had 'greatly muddied the waters' for Afghanistan's reconstruction, and created a corrosive sentiment among Afghan people who thought the system was allowing the Taliban 'in through the back door'.[56] In April, Manmohan Singh urged US Senator Howard Berman to push Obama to 'stay the course in Afghanistan', an endeavour in which India was happy to support by offering large-scale training to the Afghan National Police (ANP).[57] Raghavan and Singh's requests did not cut any ice with the White House.[58] Increment in India's training of the ANP, Washington argued, would put more strain on India-Pakistan relations, and make it difficult for the US to move forward with its Af-Pak policy (Holbrooke pushed this issue strongly with Narayanan and asked India to stick to Afghanistan's agricultural sector).[59] In June, US National Security Advisor James Jones told Singh (and other top Indian leadership including Narayanan and defence minister A. K. Antony) that despite the deteriorating of the security situation since 2007 (as India had correctly warned), military options were no longer dominant in the new US approach towards Afghanistan.[60] There were reasons for India's diplomatic activism. Patil, at the JIC, had begun receiving troubling intercepts from Kashmir-centric militants. Obama's announcement, as he puts it: 'changed the rhetoric coming from groups like Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammad. I saw multiple intercepts saying "our Taliban brothers have been successful in defeating the US in Afghanistan, and we will do the same to India in Kashmir .... [and] that the Taliban are coming, and Afghanis are coming, so we should step up the fight". Eventually we realised that this was just pep-talk. However, our initial concern